OpenAI API Key Free: How to Get a Free API Key for ChatGPT Projects

Free API Key · ChatGPT Projects | Updated October 28, 2026

If you are searching for an **OpenAI API key free** option for a ChatGPT project, website, chatbot, or software application, you can create your own API key through the official OpenAI API platform. The key is used to authenticate applications when they communicate with the OpenAI API. However, an API key and free API usage are two different things. OpenAI manages ChatGPT and API billing separately, so having access to ChatGPT does not automatically provide unlimited API usage.

An OpenAI API key can be useful for developers who want to build custom AI applications instead of using ChatGPT only through its standard interface. You can connect the API to a website, chatbot, content tool, automation workflow, educational application, business tool, or personal project.

If your main goal is to find a **free ChatGPT API key** or **free OpenAI API key**, the right approach is to create your own credential, check the API billing options available to your account, and keep the key protected once it has been generated.

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What Is an OpenAI API Key?

An OpenAI API key is a secret credential that identifies your API requests. Applications use it when communicating with the OpenAI API.

OpenAI provides a dedicated API key page where you can create, manage, and delete API keys. The complete secret value is shown when the key is created, so you should save it securely at that point.

That distinction is important because searches for **OpenAI API key free** often combine two separate questions:

How do I create an API key?

and

Can I use the API without paying?

Is an OpenAI API Key Free to Create?

You can create your own OpenAI API key through the API platform rather than purchasing a key from another person or website.

However, creating an API key should not be interpreted as receiving unlimited free API requests.

OpenAI states that ChatGPT and the API platform have separate billing systems.

Free OpenAI API Key vs Free API Usage

A **free OpenAI API key** generally means you want to create your own API credential without buying one from a third party.

Free API usage means that your account has some provision under which API requests can be made without a charge.

Your key does not determine whether requests are free.

How to Get an OpenAI API Key Free

1. Sign In to Your OpenAI Account — Start by signing in to the OpenAI account you want to use for your project.

2. Open the API Platform — Go to the OpenAI API platform and open the API key management section.

3. Create a New Secret Key — Choose the option to create a new secret key.

4. Save the Key Immediately — When the secret key is created, save it somewhere secure.

5. Add the Key to Your Development Environment — Store the credential as an environment variable such as OPENAI_API_KEY.

Why the OpenAI API Key Is Important for ChatGPT Projects

For example, a custom chatbot might work like this:

User enters a message → Your website sends the message to your backend → Backend authenticates with OpenAI → OpenAI API processes the request → Backend receives the response → Website displays the response

Can You Use a Free OpenAI API Key for ChatGPT?

If you mean using the standard ChatGPT website, you do not normally need to create an API key just to have a conversation with ChatGPT.

If you mean building your own application that provides a ChatGPT-style conversational

experience, an OpenAI API key can be used by your software to authenticate API requests.

Does ChatGPT Plus Give You Free API Access?

OpenAI's current billing documentation explicitly states that ChatGPT and the API platform have separate billing systems. API usage is billed through the API platform rather than being automatically included with a ChatGPT subscription.

OpenAI API Key Free for Website Development

The recommended structure is:

Frontend → Your Backend → OpenAI API

The frontend handles the user interface. Your backend handles the API request and stores the secret credential.

Using an OpenAI API Key With Python

A basic environment-variable check can look like this:

```
import os
api_key = os.environ.get("OPENAI_API_KEY")
if not api_key: raise RuntimeError("OPENAI_API_KEY is not configured")
```

This keeps the actual credential outside the Python source file.

Using the OpenAI API Key With Node.js

A basic configuration can read the environment variable like this:

```
const apiKey = process.env.OPENAI_API_KEY;
```

if (!apiKey) { throw new Error("OPENAI_API_KEY is missing"); }

The key should remain on the server.

OpenAI API Key Free for a Chatbot

For example, a chatbot could include:

Custom branding
Conversation history
User accounts
Database integration
AI-powered search
Customer-support functionality
Content assistance
Internal business tools
Usage tracking

Free OpenAI API Key for Personal Projects

A simple project allows you to learn:

API authentication
Environment variables
API requests
Response handling
Error handling
Usage monitoring
Security practices

Can You Get Unlimited Free OpenAI API Usage?

An API key does not provide unlimited free API usage.

OpenAI's API platform has its own billing system, and API charges depend on the models and features used.

How API Billing Works

OpenAI's current documentation states that paid API usage can be started by adding a payment method in the API account billing settings. API charges depend on the models and features used, including token usage and applicable tool or storage charges.

How to Keep API Costs Under Control

OpenAI provides project-level usage and spend controls. Projects can be used to organize work, track usage within a defined scope, and configure limits.

How to Secure Your Free OpenAI API Key

Store It in an Environment Variable — Use OPENAI_API_KEY=your-secret-key instead of writing the real credential directly into application code.

Keep It Away From Frontend Code — Do not put the API key inside browser JavaScript.

Do Not Commit the Key to GitHub — A secret key should never be committed to a repository.

What to Do If Your API Key Is Leaked

A simple recovery process is:

1. Delete the exposed API key.
2. Review recent API usage.

3. Create a replacement key.
4. Update your application.
5. Check your source code for other copies.
6. Continue monitoring your API account.

Should You Use a Shared Free API Key?

It is better to create your own API key.

OpenAI explicitly says API keys are intended to be used by the person to whom they belong and does not support sharing API keys.

Using Different Keys for Different Projects

For example:

Website → Website API key

Chatbot → Chatbot API key

Development → Development API key

OpenAI API Key Permissions

OpenAI currently documents three project API key permission levels:

All — full permissions

Restricted — selected read and write permissions

Read Only — read permissions across endpoints

What If You Lose Your OpenAI API Key?

OpenAI states that the full secret is only displayed when the key is created. If the value is lost, create a new key and update the application.

Free OpenAI API Key for WordPress

If you are developing a custom WordPress integration, store the secret securely on the server and have server-side PHP make the API request.

Do not put the actual OpenAI API key into publicly accessible JavaScript or page HTML.

OpenAI API Key Free: Common Mistakes to Avoid

Confusing ChatGPT With the API — ChatGPT and the API platform are separate products and billing systems.

Hardcoding the Secret — Putting the key directly into application code makes accidental exposure easier.

Publishing the Key — Never publish the actual credential.

Using a Shared Credential — Create your own API key.

Ignoring Usage — Monitor API activity.

Forgetting to Rotate Keys — OpenAI recommends a regular key rotation process.

Frequently Asked Questions

How can I get an OpenAI API key free? You can create your own API key through the OpenAI API platform.

Is the OpenAI API key free? You can create and manage an OpenAI API key through the official API platform. However, having an API key does not mean that API requests are unlimited or permanently free.

Is there a free ChatGPT API key? You can create an OpenAI API key for applications that use the OpenAI API.

Does ChatGPT Free include API access? ChatGPT and the API platform have separate billing systems.

Does ChatGPT Plus include OpenAI API usage? ChatGPT subscriptions and API usage are billed separately.

Where can I create an OpenAI API key? OpenAI provides an API key page where you can create, manage, and delete API keys.

Can I use an OpenAI API key for a chatbot? Yes. An OpenAI API key can authenticate API requests from a backend powering a custom chatbot.

Can I use an OpenAI API key on my website? Yes. The secret key should remain on your backend.

Where should I store my OpenAI API key? OpenAI recommends storing the credential in an environment variable such as OPENAI_API_KEY.

Can I share my OpenAI API key? OpenAI does not support sharing API keys.

What should I do if my OpenAI API key is exposed? Delete or revoke the exposed key, create a replacement, update your application, and review API activity.

Can I create multiple API keys? Yes. API keys can be managed at the project level.

Can OpenAI API keys have different permissions? Yes. Project API keys can be configured with All, Restricted, or Read Only permissions.

Does an API key provide unlimited free ChatGPT requests? No. An API key is an authentication credential rather than an unlimited free-use plan.

Final Thoughts

An **OpenAI API key free** search usually comes from developers who want to start building an AI-powered project without purchasing a credential from a third party. The correct approach is to create your own OpenAI API key through the official API platform and then check the API account for the current billing and usage options.

For a secure development setup, keep the credential in OPENAI_API_KEY, route website requests through your backend, avoid public repositories, monitor API activity, and rotate keys when appropriate.

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